

Advanced Engineering Mathematics

# Complex Numbers

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# 1 Complex Numbers

## Key Concept

A **complex number** is written in rectangular form as

$$z = x + iy,$$

where  $x, y \in \mathbb{R}$  and  $i^2 = -1$ .

The quantities

$$\operatorname{Re}(z) = x, \quad \operatorname{Im}(z) = y$$

are called the **real part** and **imaginary part** of  $z$ , respectively.

The **complex conjugate** of  $z$  is

$$z^* = x - iy,$$

and the **modulus** of  $z$  is

$$|z| = \sqrt{x^2 + y^2}.$$

Complex numbers extend the real number system in a natural way. In earlier engineering mathematics, variables were often real-valued. Now the independent or dependent variable may be complex. This is important because many engineering tools, especially the Laplace transform and the  $Z$ -transform, use complex variables.

A useful viewpoint is geometric: the number

$$z = x + iy$$

is represented by the point  $(x, y)$  in the complex plane. The horizontal axis is the real axis, and the vertical axis is the imaginary axis.

### Key Concept

For

$$z_1 = x_1 + iy_1, \quad z_2 = x_2 + iy_2,$$

the basic operations are

$$z_1 + z_2 = (x_1 + x_2) + i(y_1 + y_2),$$

$$z_1 - z_2 = (x_1 - x_2) + i(y_1 - y_2),$$

$$z_1 z_2 = (x_1 x_2 - y_1 y_2) + i(x_1 y_2 + x_2 y_1),$$

and if  $z_2 \neq 0$ ,

$$\frac{z_1}{z_2} = \frac{(x_1 + iy_1)(x_2 - iy_2)}{x_2^2 + y_2^2}.$$

Also,

$$zz^* = |z|^2 = x^2 + y^2, \quad \operatorname{Re}(z) = \frac{z + z^*}{2}, \quad \operatorname{Im}(z) = \frac{z - z^*}{2i}.$$

## Motivation and Intuition

Why do we need complex numbers in engineering? A sinusoid such as

$$A \cos(\omega t + \phi)$$

can be handled much more efficiently through

$$Ae^{i(\omega t + \phi)}.$$

Instead of separating magnitude and phase repeatedly, complex numbers allow both to be carried at once in a single expression.

## Geometric Interpretation

If  $z = x + iy$ , then:

- $|z|$  is the distance from the origin to the point  $z$ .
- $z^*$  is the reflection of  $z$  across the real axis.
- Addition corresponds to vector addition in the plane.
- Multiplication has a deeper geometric meaning that becomes clearer in polar form.

## Key Properties

### Key Concept

Important modulus properties:

$$|z_1 z_2| = |z_1| |z_2|, \quad \left| \frac{z_1}{z_2} \right| = \frac{|z_1|}{|z_2|} \quad (z_2 \neq 0),$$

$$|z_1 + z_2| \leq |z_1| + |z_2|$$

(the triangle inequality).

These are frequently used in complex analysis, signal processing, and control.

### Example

#### Example 1: Simplify a quotient

Simplify

$$\frac{3 - 2i}{-1 + i}.$$

Multiply numerator and denominator by the conjugate of the denominator:

$$\frac{3 - 2i}{-1 + i} \cdot \frac{-1 - i}{-1 - i} = \frac{(3 - 2i)(-1 - i)}{(-1 + i)(-1 - i)}.$$

Compute the numerator:

$$(3 - 2i)(-1 - i) = -3 - 3i + 2i + 2i^2.$$

Since  $i^2 = -1$ ,

$$-3 - 3i + 2i + 2(-1) = -5 - i.$$

Compute the denominator:

$$(-1 + i)(-1 - i) = (-1)^2 - i^2 = 1 - (-1) = 2.$$

Hence,

$$\frac{3 - 2i}{-1 + i} = \frac{-5 - i}{2} = -\frac{5}{2} - \frac{1}{2}i.$$

### Example

**Example 2:** Use the conjugate to find real and imaginary parts

Let

$$z = 4 - 3i.$$

Then

$$z^* = 4 + 3i.$$

Now,

$$\operatorname{Re}(z) = \frac{z + z^*}{2} = \frac{(4 - 3i) + (4 + 3i)}{2} = \frac{8}{2} = 4,$$

and

$$\operatorname{Im}(z) = \frac{z - z^*}{2i} = \frac{(4 - 3i) - (4 + 3i)}{2i} = \frac{-6i}{2i} = -3.$$

### Engineering Note

In AC circuit analysis, impedance is written as a complex number:

$$Z = R + iX,$$

where  $R$  is resistance and  $X$  is reactance. This compact form allows algebraic handling of phase shifts and amplitudes in one framework.

## Common Mistakes / Notes

- Do not confuse  $z^2$  with  $|z|^2$ . In general,

$$z^2 = (x + iy)^2 = x^2 - y^2 + i2xy,$$

whereas

$$|z|^2 = x^2 + y^2.$$

- The imaginary part of  $z = x + iy$  is  $y$ , not  $iy$ .
- When dividing complex numbers, always rationalize the denominator using the conjugate.

## 2 Polar Form

### Key Concept

If

$$z = x + iy,$$

then we may also write it in polar form as

$$z = r(\cos \theta + i \sin \theta) = re^{i\theta},$$

where

$$r = |z| = \sqrt{x^2 + y^2}, \quad x = r \cos \theta, \quad y = r \sin \theta.$$

Here  $r$  is the **modulus** and  $\theta$  is an **argument** of  $z$ .

Polar form is especially useful because multiplication, division, powers, and roots become much simpler than in rectangular form.

### Motivation / Intuition

In rectangular form, multiplication mixes real and imaginary parts. In polar form, multiplication becomes:

$$r_1 e^{i\theta_1} \cdot r_2 e^{i\theta_2} = (r_1 r_2) e^{i(\theta_1 + \theta_2)}.$$

So multiplication means:

- multiply the magnitudes,
- add the angles.

That is exactly why polar form is powerful in engineering applications involving gain and phase.

### Geometric Interpretation

The number  $z = re^{i\theta}$  is the point whose distance from the origin is  $r$  and whose angle from the positive real axis is  $\theta$ .

Because angles differing by multiples of  $2\pi$  represent the same direction,

$$\theta, \quad \theta + 2\pi, \quad \theta + 4\pi, \dots$$

all correspond to the same complex number.

### Key Concept

The argument is **not unique**. If  $\theta$  is one argument of  $z \neq 0$ , then every argument is

$$\theta + 2k\pi, \quad k \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

A commonly chosen value is the **principal argument**, denoted  $\text{Arg } z$ .

## Key Properties / Theorems

### Key Concept

Euler's formula:

$$e^{i\theta} = \cos \theta + i \sin \theta.$$

De Moivre's theorem:

$$(re^{i\theta})^n = r^n e^{in\theta} = r^n (\cos(n\theta) + i \sin(n\theta)).$$

### Key Concept

For nonzero complex numbers,

$$z_1 = r_1 e^{i\theta_1}, \quad z_2 = r_2 e^{i\theta_2},$$

we have

$$\begin{aligned} z_1 z_2 &= r_1 r_2 e^{i(\theta_1 + \theta_2)}, \\ \frac{z_1}{z_2} &= \frac{r_1}{r_2} e^{i(\theta_1 - \theta_2)}. \end{aligned}$$

### Example

#### Example 1: Convert to polar form

Express

$$z = -\sqrt{6} - i\sqrt{2}$$

in polar form.

First compute the modulus:

$$r = \sqrt{(-\sqrt{6})^2 + (-\sqrt{2})^2} = \sqrt{6 + 2} = 2\sqrt{2}.$$

Now determine the argument. Since

$$\tan \theta = \frac{-\sqrt{2}}{-\sqrt{6}} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{3}},$$

the reference angle is

$$\frac{\pi}{6}.$$

Because  $z$  lies in the third quadrant, the correct argument is

$$\theta = \pi + \frac{\pi}{6} = \frac{7\pi}{6}.$$

Hence,

$$z = 2\sqrt{2} e^{i7\pi/6}.$$

### Example

**Example 2: Compute a power using De Moivre's theorem**

Find

$$(1 + i)^4.$$

First convert  $1 + i$  to polar form.

Its modulus is

$$r = \sqrt{1^2 + 1^2} = \sqrt{2},$$

and its argument is

$$\theta = \frac{\pi}{4}.$$

Thus,

$$1 + i = \sqrt{2} e^{i\pi/4}.$$

Raise to the fourth power:

$$(1 + i)^4 = \left( \sqrt{2} e^{i\pi/4} \right)^4 = (\sqrt{2})^4 e^{i\pi} = 4(-1) = -4.$$

### Example

**Example 3: Find cube roots**

Find all cube roots of

$$-1 + i.$$



Write the number in polar form. Its modulus is

$$r = \sqrt{(-1)^2 + 1^2} = \sqrt{2},$$

and one argument is

$$\phi = \frac{3\pi}{4}.$$

So

$$-1 + i = \sqrt{2} e^{i3\pi/4}.$$

The cube roots are

$$z_k = r^{1/3} e^{i(\phi+2k\pi)/3}, \quad k = 0, 1, 2.$$

Since

$$r^{1/3} = (\sqrt{2})^{1/3} = 2^{1/6},$$

we obtain

$$z_k = 2^{1/6} e^{i(\frac{3\pi}{4}+2k\pi)/3}, \quad k = 0, 1, 2.$$

Thus:

$$z_0 = 2^{1/6} e^{i\pi/4}, \quad z_1 = 2^{1/6} e^{i11\pi/12}, \quad z_2 = 2^{1/6} e^{i19\pi/12}.$$

### Engineering Note

In frequency-response analysis, a transfer function value is often written as

$$H(i\omega) = |H(i\omega)| e^{i\phi(\omega)}.$$

The modulus gives gain and the argument gives phase shift. This is one reason polar form is central in electrical and control engineering.

### Common Mistakes / Notes

- Do not determine  $\theta$  using only  $\tan^{-1}(y/x)$  without checking the quadrant.
- Remember that the argument is multivalued:

$$\arg z = \theta + 2k\pi.$$

- For roots, do not stop at one answer. An  $n$ th root problem has  $n$  distinct roots.

### 3 Complex Variables

#### Key Concept

A **complex variable** is a variable of the form

$$z = x + iy,$$

where both  $x$  and  $y$  may vary independently over subsets of  $\mathbb{R}$ .

Unlike a real variable, which moves along a line, a complex variable moves in a plane. This makes the behavior of complex functions richer and also more restrictive when differentiability is required.

#### Motivation / Intuition

In real calculus, a variable changes along one direction. In complex analysis, a variable can approach a point from infinitely many directions. This extra geometric freedom is the reason the theory becomes both more subtle and more powerful.

#### Formal Definitions

##### Key Concept

A **neighborhood** of  $z_0$  is a disk

$$\{z : |z - z_0| < \varepsilon\}, \quad \varepsilon > 0.$$

A **deleted neighborhood** of  $z_0$  is

$$\{z : 0 < |z - z_0| < \varepsilon\}.$$

A set is **open** if every point in it has a neighborhood contained in the set.

A set is **connected** if any two points in it can be joined by a path lying entirely in the set.

A **domain** is an open, connected set.

These ideas are needed because analyticity is not defined at just one isolated point. It is defined in neighborhoods and domains.

## Geometric Interpretation

- The set

$$|z| < 1$$

is the open unit disk.

- The set

$$|z| \leq 1$$

contains the boundary circle and is not open.

- The set

$$0 < |z| < 1$$

is punctured at the origin but is still connected.

## Key Ideas

### Key Concept

Complex analysis is local. To say a function behaves well at a point, we usually require good behavior not just at that point but in some neighborhood around it.

This is why concepts such as open sets and domains are not merely formal language. They are essential.

### Example

#### Example 1: Identify a domain

Determine whether

$$D = \{z : |z| < 2\}$$

is a domain.

The set consists of all points inside the circle of radius 2 centered at the origin.

It is open because each interior point has a small disk around it that still lies inside  $D$ .

It is connected because any two points inside the disk can be joined by a line segment lying inside the disk.

Hence,

$$D$$

is a domain.

### Example

#### Example 2: A set that is not a domain

Consider

$$S = \{z : |z| < 1\} \cup \{z : |z - 4| < 1\}.$$

This is the union of two disjoint open disks.

It is open, because each disk is open.

However, it is not connected: a point in the first disk cannot be joined to a point in the second disk by a path staying entirely inside  $S$ .

Therefore,  $S$  is not a domain.

### Engineering Note

In engineering, domains arise naturally when discussing where a transfer function is valid, where a logarithm is single-valued, or where a conformal map can be used safely.

### Common Mistakes / Notes

- A set can be open without being connected.
- A set can be connected even if it has a hole.
- Analyticity is always discussed with respect to a domain, not just isolated points.